

Of sports spectatorship

Spectators identifying with winners is almost a cliché. Watching top athletes winning their events, it is **easy to imagine** that they don't just represent their countries but humankind itself.

Suresh Menon

Why do we watch sport? It's a question that kept popping into my head, as it has been doing on and off for many years now, while watching the World Athletics Championships. Perhaps it was the presence of my wife for many of the events that made it more intriguing. For one, she barely watches sport. And yet here she was enjoying the high jump and the discus throw and the 10,000 metre races without knowing anything about the competitors or the countries they represented.

Perhaps there is a purity in this kind of viewing. There is, too, no emotional involvement that often ruins sport for those who watch only for the results and to bask in the reflected glory of national victories.

Triumphalism accompanies competition, but often limits the pleasure. Obviously more books are written about how to play than how to watch. Sports spectatorship isn't a field of study; I am not even sure if it ought to be.

In his book *In Praise of Athletic Beauty*, Hans Ulrich Gumbrecht, a professor of literature, evokes Immanuel Kant and argues that spectatorship is "disinterested satisfaction" in a nonutilitarian performance. Here, 'disinterested' is used in the original sense of having no vested interest (unfortunately the word has since become a synonym for 'uninterested'). He says, too, that there is no ugly play, only one that "fails to fulfill the form it was supposed to become."

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Watching top athletes Armand Duplantis, Hamish Kerr, Faith Kipyegon winning their events, it is easy to imagine that they don't just represent their countries but humankind itself. We watch the champions and are grateful to them because it removes from us the responsibility of having to train and sacrifice and give up the goodies while they do these things on our behalf. **Only one man has run the 100 metres in 9.53 seconds, but the rest of us can glow in Usain Bolt's achievements.**

I once read about someone saying, "By watching sports, we can enjoy, in our imagination, certain lives that we have neither the talent nor the time to live." Perhaps that is the essence of spectatorship. As Gumbrecht writes, "Watching sports can allow us to be suddenly, somehow, one with those beautiful and beautifully transfigured bodies."

But it's not always the winners. Sport has more losers than winners, and more of us have lost in sport than won. It is not unusual to identify with the runner at the back of the field, the thrower who messes up all his throws or finishes so far back he needs understanding rather than approbation. The sensitive spectator is aware of this. Many in India will forget who won, but will remember the heroics of Sarvesh Kushare (**in pic**) who cleared his personal best to finish sixth in the high jump and had a nation holding its breath while he attempted 2.31m and failed.

It brought together a nice mix of patriotism, emotional involvement, aesthetics, admiration and acceptance. Sport can do that.